Buddhism and a ‘second Buddha’ to some, was said to have taught here in the second century CE (though evidence for this is scant).

When Faxian passed through the adjoining ‘village of Nala’ in c. 407 CE, he noted a stupa with relics of Sariputra, one of the two closest disciples of the Buddha. Sariputra, the locals told Faxian, was a native of Nala and so was cremated at the site of the stupa. Oddly, no community of monks had grown around the relics of a figure as eminent as Sariputra. Faxian did not mention any such community. It’s therefore reasonable to conclude that there was no monastery at Nalanda when Faxian visited in the early fifth century CE.

Nalanda Mahavihara likely arose a few years after Faxian’s visit—during the reign of Kumaragupta (reigned c. 414–55 CE)—and lasted around eight centuries. The site’s legendary links with great names may well have shaped the decision to locate the monastery there.

After its demise in the thirteenth century, Nalanda lay forgotten and buried under mounds of earth for centuries. It was Stanislas Julien’s French translation of Xuanzang’s travels in 1853 that kindled interest among colonial archaeologists in identifying the site, which they soon did. In 1862, Alexander Cunningham and the freshly minted Archaeological Survey of India, which he founded, surveyed the site. The ASI led formal excavations and restorations at Nalanda from 1915–37 and then again from 1974–82.

Their work uncovered eleven monasteries, six temples and a giant stupa, aka the Great Monument. The monasteries, laid out in a row, face a parallel row of temples directly across. A 30-metre-wide path runs between the two rows. Each monastery, averaging about 40m x 60m, is made of oblong red bricks, once plastered with a paste of lime and sand. In Yijing’s time, there were seven monasteries, all ‘very similar in general appearance and layout; if you see one, you have seen all the seven’.[3]